Telford & Wrekin Council

Protect, care and invest to create a better borough

BRIEFING FOR THE SCRUTINY COMMITTEE

Corporate Feedback Report 2023/24

More complaints, faster answers — and a tighter 10-day clock from May 2024

659

corporate Stage One complaints
up from 601 in 2022/23

87%

answered within 15 working days
up from 80% in 2022/23

Source: Corporate Feedback Report 2023/24

Telford & Wrekin Council · Customer Relationship team
Reporting year 1 April 2023 – 31 March 2024

OVERVIEW

More complaints, answered faster

Volume and speed both rose at Stage One; escalations to Stage Two rose faster still.

STAGE ONE COMPLAINTS

659

2022/23: 601

From 619 complainants; still under 1% of all transactions

ANSWERED WITHIN 15 DAYS

87%

2022/23: 80%

Local target is **90%** ; five directorates met it

AVERAGE RESPONSE TIME

10 days

2022/23: 11 days

Working days at Stage One; **26** went past the 20-day limit

ESCALATED TO STAGE TWO

70

2022/23: 41

Full investigations averaged **43** working days (28 before)

42%

upheld at Stage One — unchanged from 2022/23

639

compliments received — up 13% on 566 in 2022/23

100%

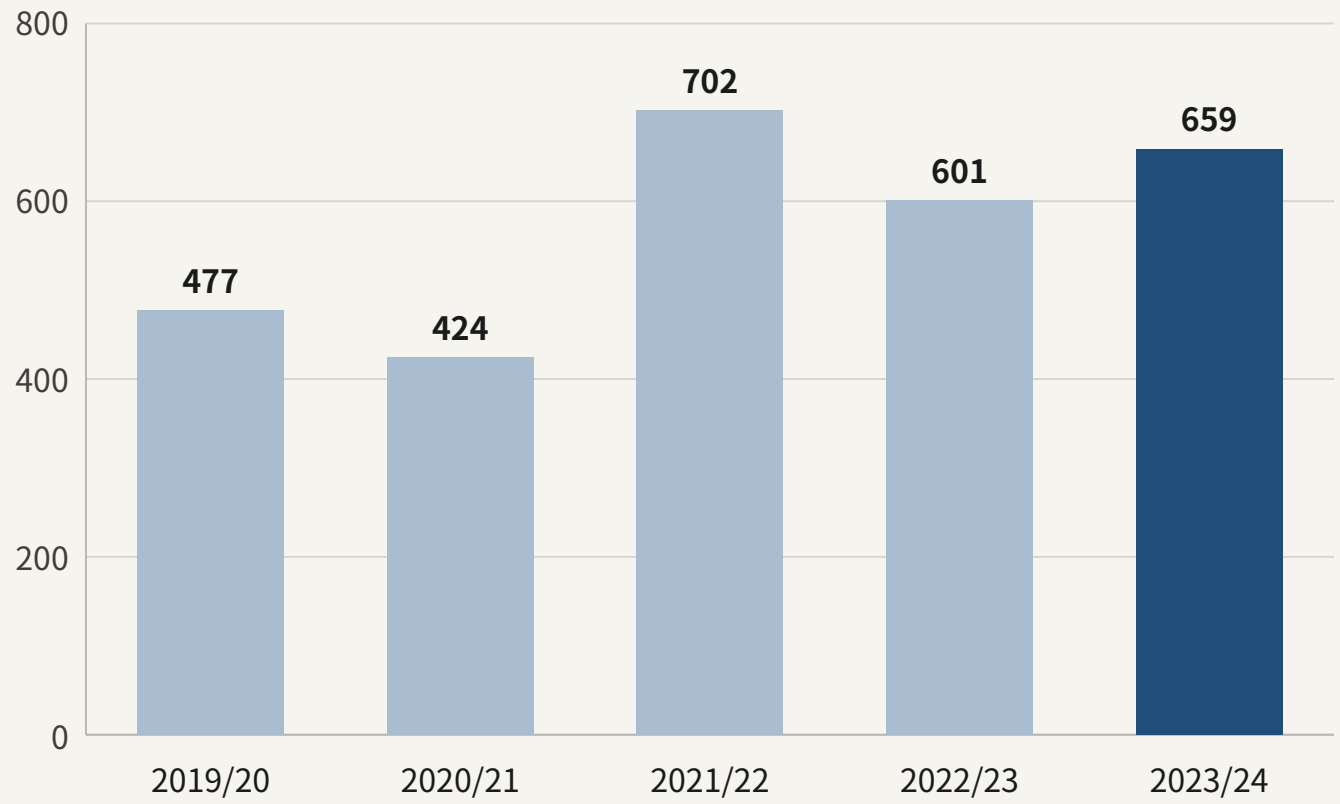
of Ombudsman recommendations completed

Source: Telford & Wrekin Council, Corporate Feedback Report 2023/24 — Report summary; Highlights 2023/24

659 complaints: the second-highest in five years

Up from 601 in 2022/23 and below the 2021/22 peak of 702.

CORPORATE STAGE ONE COMPLAINTS BY YEAR



IN CONTEXT: COUNCIL ACTIVITY 2023/24

10.7 million
bins emptied

212,074
calls to the Corporate Contact Centre

c.160,000
council tax bills issued

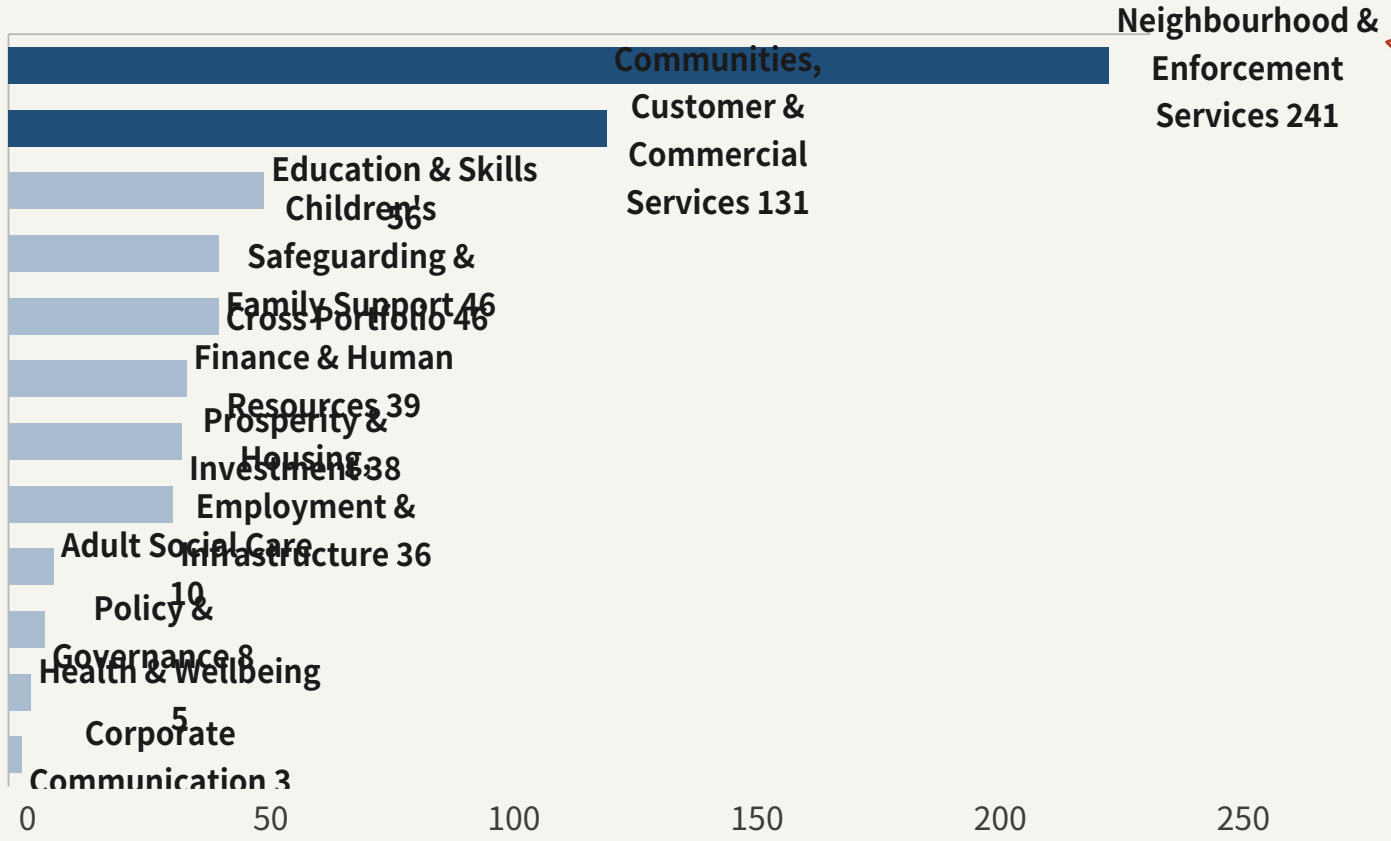
c.3.2 million
visitors welcomed to Telford

> Complaints stay **under 1%** of all transactions. The Ombudsman says complaints need not be a negative: they can signal an accessible procedure.

Source: Corporate Feedback Report 2023/24 — Chart 4 (Total Corporate Stage 1 by Year); Report summary

Two directorates received 372 of the 659 complaints

Neighbourhood & Enforcement, home to waste and highways, received 241 on its own.



DATA NOTE

Report text gives 214 (+22% on 176). Chart 6 gives **241** — the value that sums to 659.

Communities, Customer & Commercial Services
131 — up 30% on 101

Education & Skills
56 — up 70% on 33; Special Educational Needs: 31 (19 before)

Fewer than in 2022/23
Children's Safeguarding & Family Support, Prosperity & Investment, Finance & Human Resources

Source: Corporate Feedback Report 2023/24 — Chart 6 (Corporate Complaints received by Directorate) and accompanying text

Upheld themes shrank — delay fell from 24% to 9%

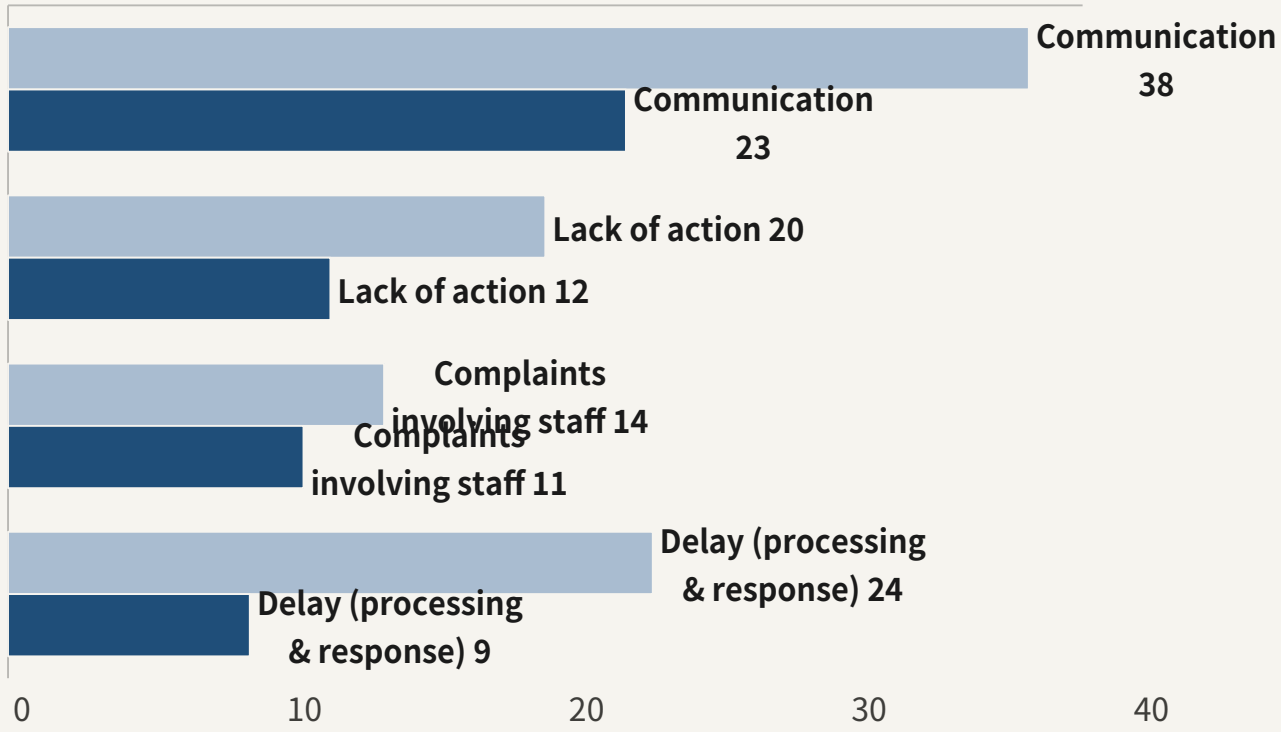
Share of the 434 upheld issues by theme — all four main themes fell.

WHAT PEOPLE RAISED

Top themes before investigation; one complaint can carry several

Communication	205
Lack of action	126
Complaints involving staff	112
Disagree with council decision	85
Request for information/service	68

The report puts communication and lack of action at **30%** of all issues raised.



Fifth theme: processing/administrative error, 4% of upheld issues in 2023/24.

Source: Corporate Feedback Report 2023/24 — Chart 5 (Complaint Themes prior to investigation); Chart 8 and text on the top five upheld themes

42% upheld — the same rate as 2022/23

The largest directorates have the most upheld complaints because they answer the most.

ALL STAGE ONE RESPONSES

42% upheld

271 of the 647 complaints answered in the year



Upheld 42% Not upheld 51% Other 7%

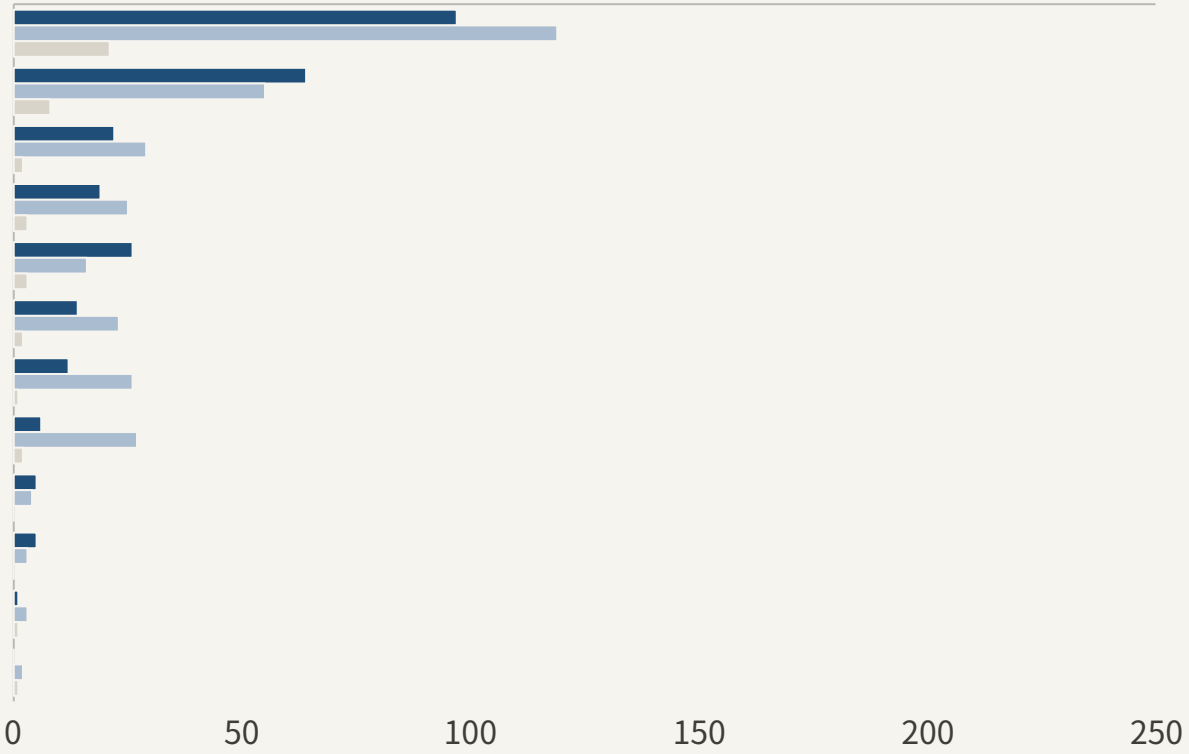
Most upheld

Neighbourhood & Enforcement: 97 (41%)

Communities, Customer & Commercial: 64 (50%)

Highest upheld rate

Policy & Governance: 63% (5 complaints)

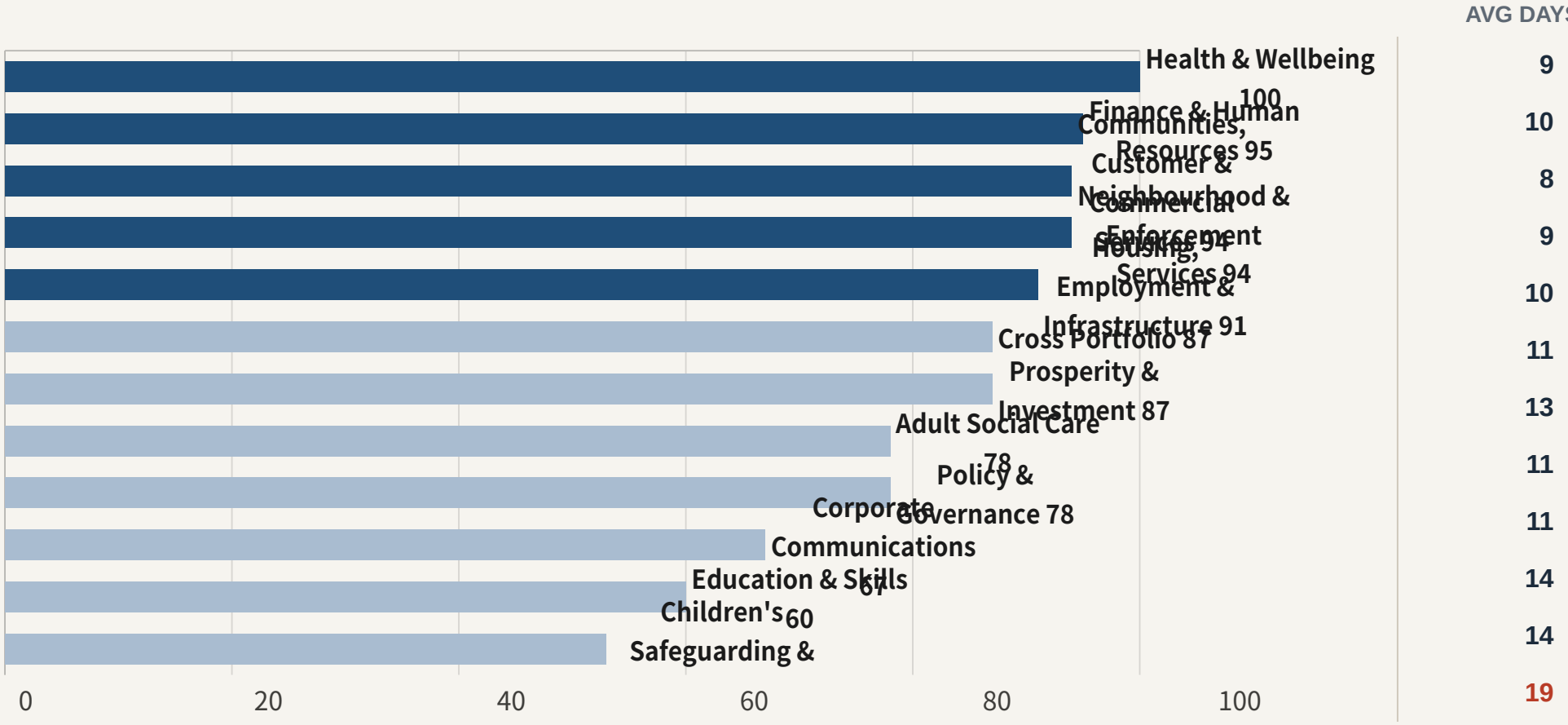


Other = service resolved, dealt with through courts, out of jurisdiction or withdrawn.

Source: Corporate Feedback Report 2023/24 — Chart 7 (Corporate Complaints Outcomes 2023/24); Stage One Complaint outcomes

87% answered in 15 days; five directorates hit 90%

Children's Safeguarding (53%) and Education & Skills (60%) lag furthest behind.



Red line: 90% local target. Navy bars met it. Brackets give the 2022/23 figure where the report states one. Avg days = working days.

Source: Corporate Feedback Report 2023/24 — Chart 9 (Response Timescales) and Timescales for responses at Stage One

Stage Two is where the pressure moved

Escalations rose 71%; full investigations more than doubled and took longer.

70
escalated to Stage Two
41 in 2022/23 (+71%)

13
still under investigation at 31 March 2024

57
investigations completed

15
closed without a full investigation — already addressed at Stage One, or no added value; answered in **8** working days on average (aim: 10)

42 full investigations (19 in 2022/23)

50%
upheld

43 days
average; 28 in 2022/23

4
over the 65-day limit

WHERE THE RISE CAME FROM (2022/23 IN BRACKETS)

Neighbourhood & Enforcement: **15** (4)
Education & Skills: **11** (3), all Special Educational Needs
Health & Wellbeing: no case escalated to Stage Two

Data note: the report gives the 2022/23 Stage Two figure as 41 (Stage Two section, used here) and as 44 (Stage One section).

Source: Corporate Feedback Report 2023/24 — Corporate Stage Two complaints; Chart 10 (Stage Two complaints by directorate)

Elected-member enquiries rose 33% to 1,507

Up from 1,132 in 2022/23; Leader and Cabinet enquiries, 1,071 of them, averaged 3 days.

Source	Received	Average time	Aim
MP enquiries	159	8 working days	10 working days
Leader of the Council	525	3 days	—
Cabinet Members	546	3 days	—
Ward Members	277	5 days	—
Total	**1,507**	—	—

MP enquiries have a 10-working-day aim; the report states no aim for the other routes. Leader enquiries come from constituents via the Leader of the Council, Cllr Shaun Davies.

DIRECT CONTACT WITH THE TEAM

1,499

emails and web forms — **up 17%** on 1,281

1,372

telephone calls — **down 18%** on 1,683

3,049

direct customer contacts in all (3,110 in 2022/23)

The Institute of Customer Service reports that nationally, voice contact has risen since the pandemic for difficult topics.

Source: Corporate Feedback Report 2023/24 — MP/Leader/Cabinet and Member Enquiries; Background; Chart 2 (Summary of other feedback)

Compliments have more than doubled in five years

639 compliments in 2023/24 — 13% more than the 566 received in 2022/23.

639

compliments received in 2023/24

2019/20	2022/23	2023/24
290	566	639

> *You were friendly, approachable and very professional, always transparent when giving us the facts.*
>
> — compliment to Adult Social Care, 2023/24

MOST COMPLIMENTED DIRECTORATES

Neighbourhood & Enforcement Services	176
Health & Wellbeing	133
Adult Social Care (34 in 2022/23)	103

CUSTOMER INSIGHT PROGRAMME

214	72	87%	71.2
Mystery Customer volunteers (+15%)	assignments since April 2023	satisfaction across them	UKCSI score (councils: 64.4)

Source: Corporate Feedback Report 2023/24 — Compliments; Chart 3 (compliments by directorate); Customer Insight Programme; Highlights 2023/24

Complaints are turning into specific fixes

Four of the 13 “You said, We did” changes the report lists for 2023/24.

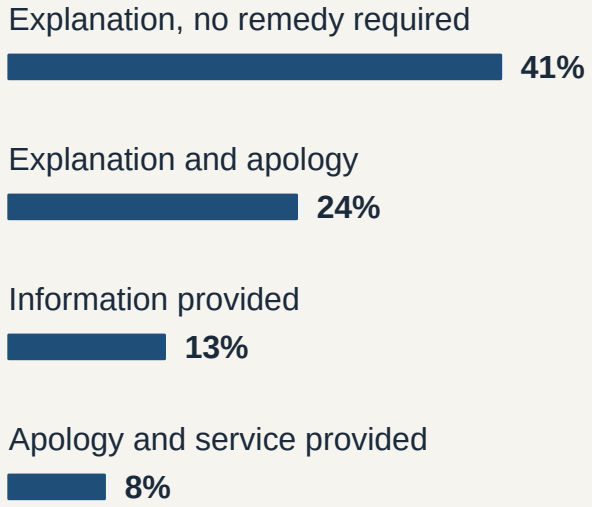
YOU SAID	WE DID
Some customers reported a delay in receiving death certificates by post.	Death certificates are now sent by First Class post.
Healthy Lifestyle customers asked for appointments after 5pm.	Extended evening clinic hours are now available throughout the week.
Leisure customers receiving Personal Independence Payment asked for concessions.	The Concessionary Policy now includes customers receiving that payment.
Bowring Park parking information missed the newer car park by the tennis courts.	The website has been updated to reflect this information.

Learning from complaints also brought a lowered accessible desk and automatic doors at Darby House Reception, twice-daily checks on postal-vote requests, and conflict resolution training for the Neighbourhood Enforcement Team.

More examples:

HOW COMPLAINTS WERE PUT RIGHT

Share of remedies recorded, 2023/24



All **271** complaints where fault was found were reviewed by the Customer Relationship team.

Source: Corporate Feedback Report 2023/24 — You said, We did; Learning and outcomes; Chart 11 (Complaint Remedies 2023/24)

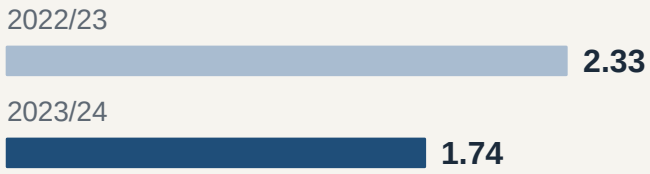
Ombudsman rate down to 1.74 per 10,000 people

One of three detailed Ombudsman investigations upheld; all recommendations completed.

OFFICE FOR LOCAL GOVERNMENT

1.74

Ombudsman complaints per 10,000 population, 2023/24



Based on a population of 188,871. OFLOG uses Ombudsman complaint data and ONS population figures.

LOCAL GOVERNMENT OMBUDSMAN

17

enquiries forwarded to the LGSCO: 12 corporate, 5 statutory

Detailed investigations completed, corporate and statutory:

3 — 1 upheld, 2 not upheld (33% upheld)

100%

of LGSCO recommendations completed

COUNCIL TENANTS

0

complaints from council tenants in 2023/24

The council became a registered provider of social housing in September 2020 and has 23 properties.

No case went to the Housing Ombudsman Service, and there were no findings of non-compliance with its Complaint Handling Code.

Source: Corporate Feedback Report 2023/24 — LGSCO enquiries; OFLOG Metrics; Complaints from Telford and Wrekin Tenants

WHAT CHANGES IN 2024/25

From May 2024, the complaints clock runs shorter

Stage One replies now have 10 working days, not 15, under the Ombudsman's complaint handling code — and the on-time target rises from 87% to 90%.

1 April 2024
Tenant complaints move into the corporate procedure

May 2024
Stage Two: 20–40 working days (was 25–65)

Autumn 2024
Second ICS benchmarking and workforce surveys

2025
Customer Service Strategy updated and relaunched

Full report:

THE 2024/25 TEST

10 days

Stage One limit (was 15)

90%

on time (87% in 2023/24)

Planned with scrutiny members

Mystery Customer assignments for the Communities Scrutiny Committee, senior managers and volunteer Mystery Customers, informing the Customer Strategy from 2025.